What is wet sanding?

Wet sanding is when an oil or wax, or sometimes a mix of the two, is used to lubricate the sanding action. The great benefit of this technique is the reduction in dust. As the lubricant gathers the dust it forms a kind of slurry, which doubles as a grain filler, leaving a very smooth surface. This isn't a technique that I often use though as the vast majority of my production work leaves the workshop unfinished, to be lacquered or sprayed by the customer. The potential contamination of an oil or wax in the wood could affect the final finish, so I don't risk it. This technique is also to be avoided on timbers with contrasting colours or spalting, as the slurry can smudge the colours, leaving the work looking dirty.

Wet sanding can leave a beautifully smooth surface and reduces the dust of sanding

What grit to stop at?

It really depends on what you are making, the finish that will be applied and the item's end purpose, as to when to stop sanding. For joinery type work that will be painted, I stop at 180 grit. For spray painted items for display work, I will go to 240 grit. High end items such as bowls, made in indigenous species, that will most likely be oiled, I will go to 400 grit. Work in dense timbers or exotics may go to 600, 800 or even 1200 grit. Harder materials such as alternative ivory, hybrid blanks or horn will then be polished further with an abrasive liquid like burnishing cream, then buffed with a mop loaded with fine abrasive, followed by a soft buffing mop.

One professional turner I know mostly makes bowls and chopping boards and tells a story of how he always sanded to 400 grit, until he heard from several customers that his bowls were too good to use. Now he stops at 320 grit, which saves him time, money on abrasive and still pleases his customers! A win-win situation if ever there was one.

Buffing with mild abrasive is ideal for very dense and alternative materials, achieving a high gloss with ease

Checking a large bowl in natural light

Double check

There is little more annoying than believing a job is finished, only to spot a fault later on. To avoid this I will subject the work to natural light, which shows up all sorts of faults that you can easily miss when the item is on the lathe and under standard flourescent workshop lighting. Spotlights set to give a raking light, shone across the work have a similar effect.

Use your hand to wipe between grits...

TOP TIP: WIPE YOUR WORK

If you were to ask me for one single piece of advice that will improve your sanding, it would be to give the surface of your work a wipe between grits. Whether you wipe with your hand, use a pad of paper towel or a soft brush, it doesn't really matter, but do it. This one thing will, I guarantee, improve the finish of your work.

As you sand, grits will naturally come away from your abrasive and gather with the dust on the surface of the work. If you blindly keep sanding through the grits, as you progress through the grits you will often pick up a loose grit of the previous coarser grades, which will scratch the surface, leaving a random mark on your work. The only way to remove this is to go back and sand through the grits again. Simply by wiping the surface between grits, it means that each time you sand, you are working on a clean surface, leaving the best possible surface, ready to apply your chosen finish.

WT_290_27_31_RICHARD_FINDLEY_TECH_bdVSmbRFsd.indd 30 03/02/2016 12:57